DATA ANALYSIS PROJECT

Sales Performance Dashboard

A practical analysis of revenue, profitability, returns and discount behaviour.

The question I wanted the dashboard to answer

Sales were growing, but I did not want to treat growth as the whole story. I built the analysis to see where revenue was actually profitable, where returns were concentrated, and which categories or locations deserved a closer look.

$2.30M	$286.4K	5,009
Gross sales	**Profit**	**Orders**
2014-2017	12.5% margin	793 customers

Dania Yasir

Excel | Power Query | Data Model | PivotTables | PivotCharts | Slicers
Performance Analysis Report

01 / CONTEXT

From transaction data to a management view

The workbook combines four source tables: Orders, Returns, People and Shipping Cost. The Orders table contains 9,994 transaction lines with customer, product, location, sales, quantity, discount and profit information. I used the other tables to add return, regional-representative and shipping-cost context.

How I structured the analysis

- Loaded the source tables through Power Query connections and kept the transformations inside the workbook.
- Used the Excel Data Model to connect the analysis and support pivot-based calculations across the tables.
- Worked with added fields such as Discount Value, COGS and Delivery Duration to move beyond a sales-only view.
- Built PivotTables, PivotCharts and slicers for category, geography, time and regional performance views.
- Kept the dataset's provided Profit measure unchanged instead of redefining it as a fully landed margin.

Primary audience

A sales director who needs a quick view of revenue, profitability, returns, geography and product performance.

Main business question

Where is sales performance genuinely healthy, and where can strong revenue figures hide weak profitability or operational risk?

Questions I used to guide the dashboard

Question	Why it matters
Is growth continuing?	Shows whether the business is expanding over time.
Which regions and categories lead?	Separates concentration from broad-based performance.
Where are margins weak?	Prevents high revenue from being mistaken for healthy performance.
Where are returns concentrated?	Highlights revenue at risk after the sale.
How does discounting relate to profit?	Tests whether sales are being bought at the expense of margin.

02 / DASHBOARD SUMMARY

The headline numbers are strong - but not equally healthy

$2.297M **Gross sales** All transaction lines	**$2.117M** **Net sales view** Excluding sales tied to returned orders	**$286.4K** **Profit** 12.5% of gross sales
5,009 **Orders** Across 793 customers	**296** **Returned orders** 5.9% of distinct orders	**$180.5K** **Returned sales exposure** 7.9% of gross sales

What stood out to me

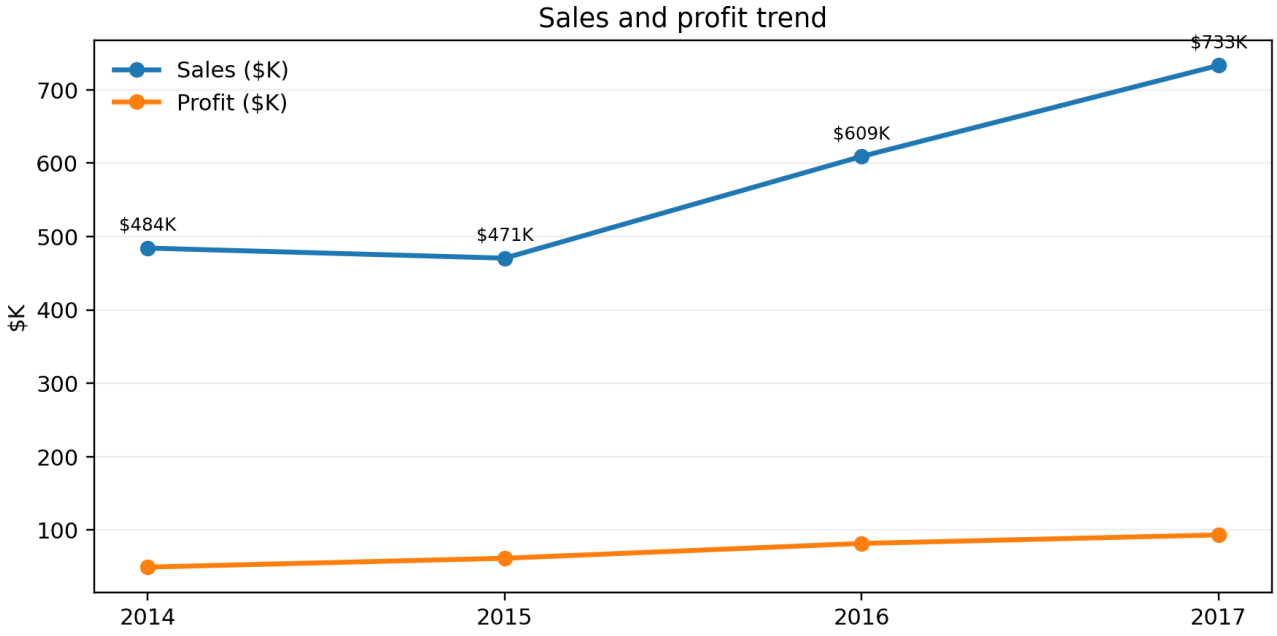
The business is not facing a simple “low sales” problem. Sales grew over time and several areas are very profitable. The more useful question is where the revenue mix is creating avoidable leakage through returns, deep discounting and low-margin product groups.

A few useful operating reference points

Metric	Result	Interpretation
Average delivery duration	4.0 days	A baseline for future service-level tracking.
Technology sales share	36.4%	Largest category by revenue.
Technology profit share	50.8%	Contributes about half of total profit.
2017 sales	$733.2K	Highest annual sales in the dataset.
2017 vs. 2016 growth	+20.4%	Growth accelerated in the final year.

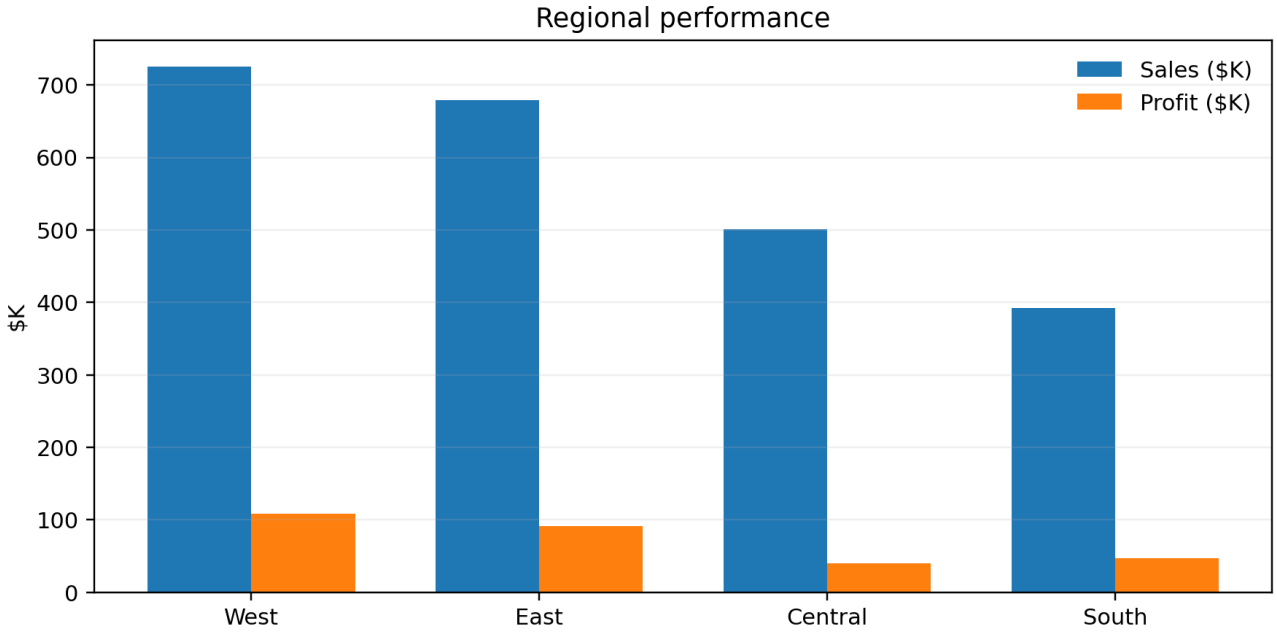
03 / TREND & GEOGRAPHY

Growth improved, but regional quality differs



Annual sales rose from $484.2K in 2014 to $733.2K in 2017. Profit increased alongside sales.

Sales were 51.4% higher in 2017 than in 2014, and 2017 finished 20.4% above 2016. I read this as a positive growth signal, but not as proof that every part of the business was improving at the same quality.

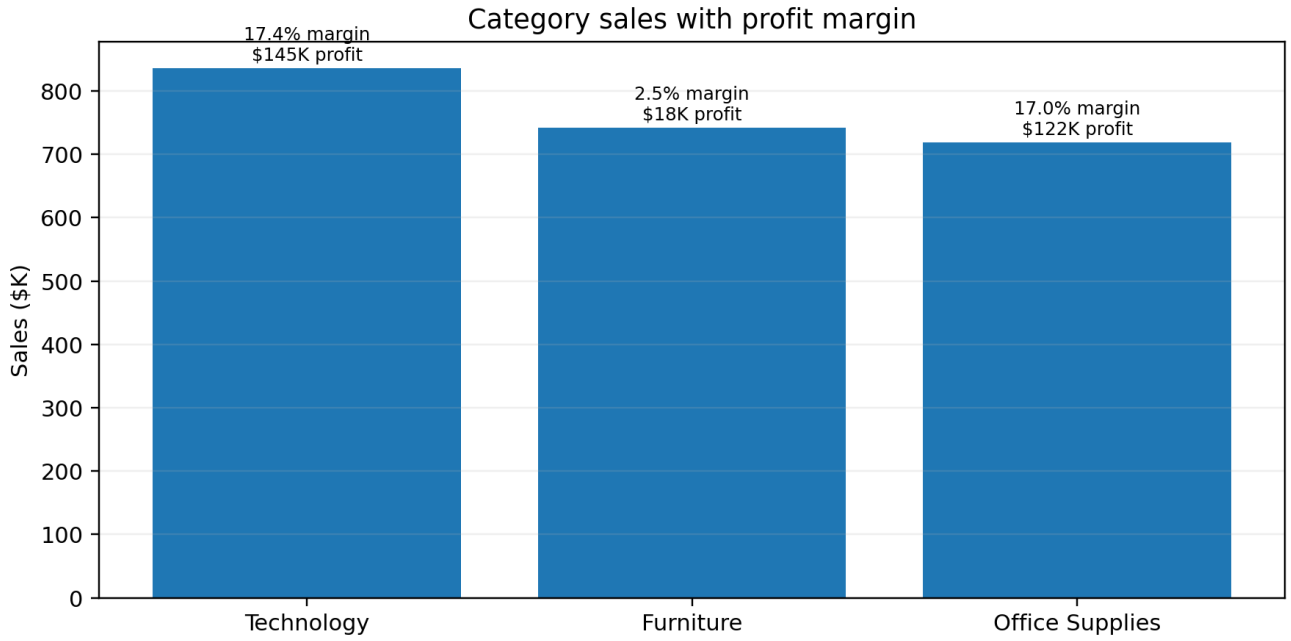


West generated the most sales and profit, followed by East.

West generated $725.5K in sales and $108.4K in profit. It outperformed South sales by 85.2%. East was close behind at $678.8K in sales and $91.5K in profit. Central produced $501.2K in sales but only $39.7K in profit, which makes margin quality worth monitoring alongside revenue.

04 / CATEGORY ECONOMICS

Furniture sells well, but it does not earn like the other categories



Sales volume is similar across the three categories, but profit margins are not.

Category	Sales	Profit	Margin
Technology	$836.2K	$145.5K	17.4%
Office Supplies	$719.0K	$122.5K	17.0%
Furniture	$742.0K	$18.5K	2.5%

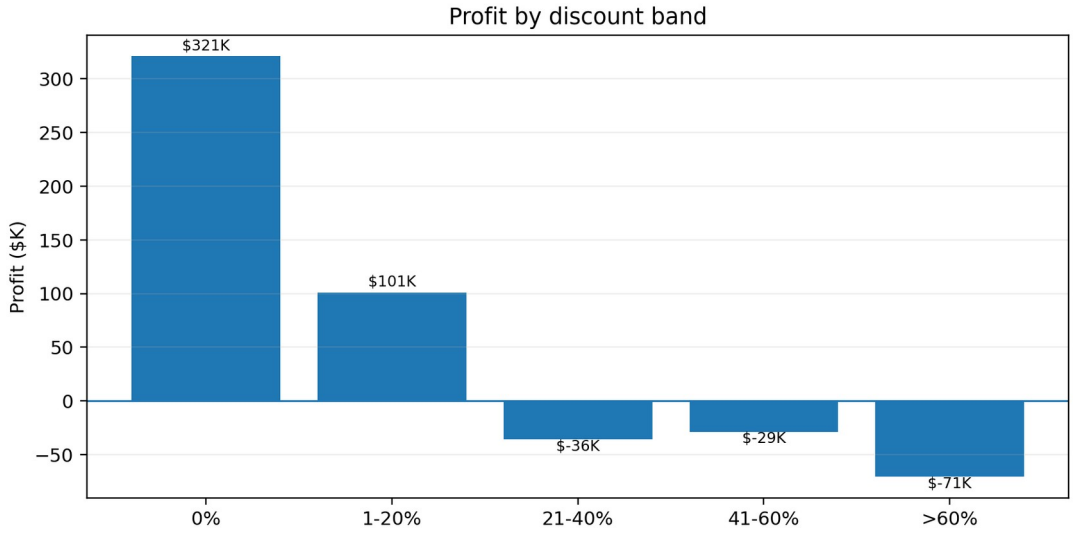
Technology is the strongest category in both scale and profit contribution: it represents 36.4% of sales and 50.8% of total profit. Office Supplies is also healthy. Furniture, however, produces almost the same sales as the other categories while delivering a much thinner margin.

The sub-category detail explains the gap

Tables generated $207.0K in sales but lost $17.7K. Bookcases lost another $3.5K. I would therefore avoid treating “Furniture” as one problem; the better next step is to isolate pricing, discounts and product mix inside the loss-making sub-categories.

05 / MARGIN LEAKAGE

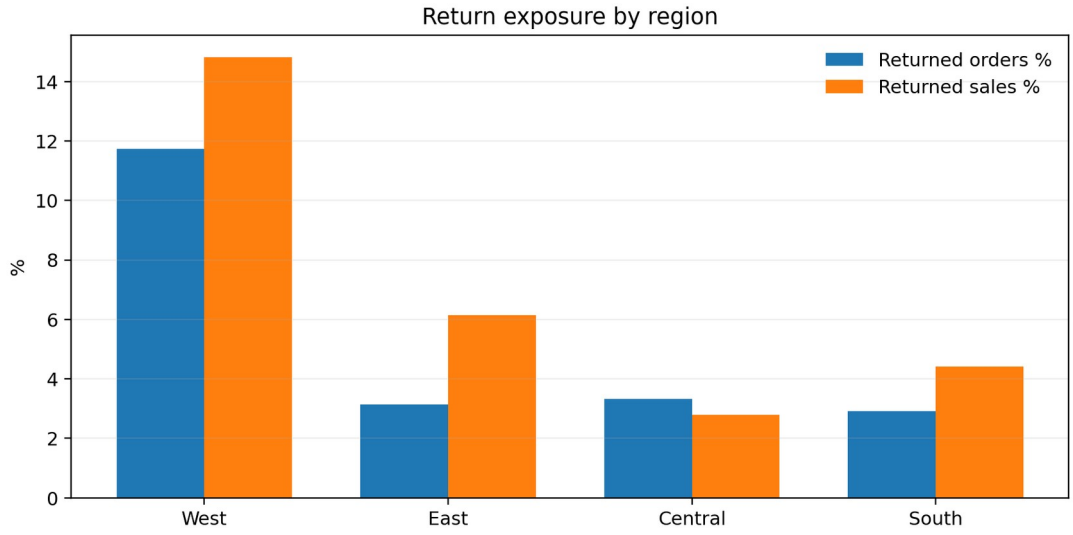
The clearest warning is what happens after discounting becomes aggressive



Profit turns negative in every discount band above 20%.

Transactions discounted above 20% generated about $362.8K in sales but a combined loss of $135.4K. By comparison, the 0% and 1-20% discount bands generated $1.93M in sales and $421.8K in profit.

> **Important interpretation**
>
> This is a strong pattern, but I would not call discounting the sole cause of the losses without controlling for product and market mix. The result is useful because it tells management exactly where to investigate first.



West leads sales, but it also has the highest return exposure in the workbook.

West had an 11.7% returned-order rate and returned sales equal to 14.8% of its gross sales. The other regions were much lower on returned-order rate: East 3.1%, Central 3.3% and South 2.9%. This changes how I would read West: it is the top revenue region, but it should also be the first region reviewed for return reasons and product mix.

06 / DECISION SUPPORT

Where I would focus next

High-sales locations that still lose money

State	Sales	Profit / Loss
Texas	$170.2K	-$25.7K
Pennsylvania	$116.5K	-$15.6K
Florida	$89.5K	-$3.4K
Illinois	$80.2K	-$12.6K
Ohio	$78.3K	-$17.0K
North Carolina	$55.6K	-$7.5K

These states are useful because they show why sales rank and performance rank are not the same thing. Texas, for example, is the third-largest state by sales but has the largest state-level loss.

Recommended management actions

- Review pricing and approval rules for discounts above 20%, starting with Tables and other loss-making product/location combinations.
- Investigate West-region returns by product, customer and time period before pushing for more volume in the region.
- Protect profitable growth in Technology and Office Supplies while fixing Furniture margin at sub-category level rather than cutting the whole category.
- Track gross sales, returned sales exposure, profit margin, deep-discount sales share and delivery duration together on a monthly management view.
- Avoid ranking regional representatives on sales alone because each representative is tied to a different region and therefore a different market mix.

07 / WHAT I WOULD IMPROVE NEXT

What this dashboard answers - and what it does not

The dashboard gives a solid management view of sales performance, but I kept a few boundaries clear while interpreting it. That was important to me because a clean dashboard can still lead to a weak decision if the measure behind it is misunderstood.

Boundary	How I treated it
Profit definition	I used the Profit field provided in the project data. The workbook contains a state-level shipping cost reference, but I did not silently fold it into profit.
Returned sales	$180.5K is the sales value tied to returned orders. I treated it as return exposure, not as a verified cash-refund amount.
Discount relationship	The negative profit pattern above 20% is descriptive evidence, not a causal experiment. Product and geographic mix may also contribute.
Regional rep comparison	People are assigned by region, so rep results are inseparable from regional market mix in this dataset.

If I extended the project

- Add return reasons so the dashboard can distinguish product issues, service issues and customer-driven returns.
- Build a landed-margin view that explicitly incorporates shipping cost and any other fulfilment expenses.
- Add channel or campaign data to understand what is driving profitable customer acquisition rather than only completed sales.
- Create a monthly exception view that flags high sales + low profit, high return exposure and unusually deep discounting.

Final takeaway

The main value of this project is not the $2.3M sales figure. It is the ability to move from that headline number into the parts of the business that are growing well, the parts that are leaking margin, and the areas where management should investigate before taking action.

Dania Yasir